

shutter-speed thing becomes much easier thanks to ISO ratings, so let's shift focus a little and tell you all about the ISO.

2.5 ISO Rating

Heard about it before? Then you probably already know that it stands for the International Organisation for Standardisation. And you can find all its efforts to make standardise units – as well as the standards for photography – at www.iso.ch.

ISO and film

Anybody who's bought a roll of photographic film with some judgment would have an idea of what 'ISO' refers to. All films are assigned an ISO value – a number which signifies the film's reactivity to light. So even though people often call it the 'speed rating' of a film, it's got nothing to do with speed at all and actually only refers to its Ev (Exposure value) – the combination of aperture value and shutter speeds required for the optimal use of the film.

Typically, for the consumer, a *slow* film (with a low ISO rating) was supposed to give you better quality images and a *fast* film (with a high ISO rating) was for poor lighting conditions and poorer quality. In reality, it was all about the size of the granules in the chemicals used on the film.

ISO and digital cameras

Films don't figure at all in digicams. So why do they still have an ISO rating anyway? Let's just say that photographers all over the world have, over the years, been accustomed to using the ISO rating to instantly understand how it would work in different lighting. Digital cameras with an ISO rating of the *faster* film mimic its reactivity by amplification of the signal that the sensor receives.

The ISO control, sometimes labeled as sensitivity – might be located at different places in different cameras. It could be labelled on the camera's body or accessed through the 'Menu' command. You can now adjust the ISO rating – almost like changing the kind of film you're using. Raising the ISO rating increases shutter speeds and smaller apertures and lowers the